

Consent Form

School of Computing and Information Systems

Technology Innovation Project



Student Researchers: Anita Yang, Tammy Lee, Bella Chen, Leo Lin

Name of Participant: Skylie

1. I consent to participate in this project, the details of which have been explained to me, and I have been provided with a written plain language statement to keep.
2. I understand that the purpose of this research is to **investigate how individuals seek and provide local help within their communities, and to evaluate the potential of a digital platform to improve accessibility, trust, and efficiency in connecting people with local support services.**
3. I understand that my participation in this project is for research purposes only.
4. I acknowledge that the possible effects of participating in this research project have been explained to my satisfaction.
5. In this project I will be required to **participate in a short interview or survey about my experiences with seeking or offering local help, and I may be asked to provide feedback on a prototype or concept of a digital platform.**
6. I understand that my interviews may be audio recorded.
7. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw from this project anytime without explanation or prejudice and to withdraw any unprocessed data that I have provided.
8. I have been informed that the confidentiality of the information I provide will be safeguarded subject to any legal requirements; my data will be password protected and accessible only by the named researchers.
9. I understand that given the small number of participants involved in the study, it may not be possible to guarantee my anonymity.
10. I understand that after I sign and return this consent form, it will be retained by the student researchers.

Participant Signature:  **Date:** 29/03/2026

Interview Guide — Australia Hero

Estimated duration: 20–30 minutes **Format:** Semi-structured (follow up naturally on interesting answers)

Opening Script (read aloud)

"Hi, thanks for taking the time to speak with us today. We're a group of postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne working on a project called Australia Hero — a hyper-local platform that helps community members and students exchange small tasks and resources nearby. Before we start, you'll have received our Plain Language Statement explaining the project. Do you have any questions about it? [Pause] Great. I'd also like to ask your permission to audio record this conversation so we can review it later — is that okay? [Pause for consent form signing] Let's begin."

Section 1 — Background (3–4 min)

Goal: understand who the person is and their living context.

1. Can you tell me a bit about yourself — what you're studying or doing, and how long you've been living in your current area?
 2. How would you describe your relationship with your neighbours or the people around you?
-

Section 2 — Current Behaviours (5–7 min)

Goal: uncover real, recent experiences — not hypotheticals.

3. Think about the last time you needed help with something small — maybe borrowing something, moving a piece of furniture, or running an errand. What did you do?
 - *Follow up: Why did you choose that approach? Did it work out?*
4. Have you ever had a moment where you needed help but didn't know who to ask, or felt uncomfortable asking? Can you walk me through that situation?
5. Have you ever helped someone nearby — a neighbour, classmate, or stranger? What was that like?
 - *Follow-up: What motivated you to help? Would you do it again?*

Section 3 — Challenges & Pain Points (5 min)

Goal: validate and deepen the problem.

6. When you try to find help — whether through apps, social media, or friends — what's the most frustrating part of that process?
 7. Have you ever used a platform like Facebook groups, Nextdoor, or WhatsApp groups to ask for or offer help? What worked well, and what didn't?
 8. As an international student or someone new to the area, have you ever felt you lacked a local support network for small everyday things? Can you give an example?
-

Section 4 — Reactions to the Platform Idea (5–7 min)

Goal: gauge genuine interest and surface concerns.

[Brief explanation: "Our platform lets you post small help requests on a map — like borrowing a tool or asking for help moving a box — and nearby people can respond. There's also a reputation and reward system to build trust."]

9. What's your initial reaction to this idea?
 10. Can you imagine a situation in your own life where you'd actually use something like this? What would that look like?
 11. What would make you hesitant to use it — or stop using it after trying it once?
 - *Follow up: What would need to be true for you to feel safe interacting with a stranger through this platform?*
-

Section 5 — Trust, Safety & Incentives (5 min)

Goal: understand what builds confidence and motivates participation.

12. What would make you trust someone enough to accept help from them or offer help to them on this platform?
13. If there were a points or reputation system — where you earned recognition for helping — would that motivate you, or would it feel artificial? Why?
14. Would you prefer to remain somewhat anonymous on this platform, or would you want your real identity visible? What's your reasoning?
15. When receiving help or offering help, do you have any personal preferences regarding the helper or requester (e.g., gender, age, or other factors)?

- *Follow up:* Do you feel more comfortable interacting with someone of a particular gender in certain situations? (describe the situation)
16. Does this preference also apply when you are the one offering help to others?
-

Section 6 — Feature Priorities (3 min)

Goal: prioritise MVP features based on real user input.

17. If you could only have two or three features on this platform when it first launched, what would they be and why?
18. Is there anything you've seen in another app — not necessarily in this space — that you think would work really well here?
-

Closing (1–2 min)

19. Is there anything else about this kind of platform — or your own experiences with getting or giving help — that you think we should know?

"Thank you so much for your time. Your answers are really valuable to us. Just as a reminder, your responses will be kept confidential, referred to by a pseudonym in any reporting, and you can withdraw at any time. We'll be in touch if we have any follow-up questions."

Tips for Your Team

Before the interview: Have the Consent Form and Plain Language Statement ready. Let the participant read the PLS first, then sign the consent form before recording begins.

During: Don't rush past good stories — if someone gives a rich example, ask "can you tell me more about that?" The best insights come from specifics, not generalities.

Divide and conquer: One person asks questions, another takes notes. Rotate roles across interviews.

Target participants: Prioritise international students for interviews, as your proposal identifies them as the primary user group with the most acute pain points.

Q1

Location and Duration

- Participant 1 (HelpNet interview): [Living in South Yarra, Melbourne for 10 months](#); also in Melbourne for 10 months total
- Participant 1 identifies as an introvert with limited neighbour communication
- Limited to no face-to-face meetings with neighbours despite living in same area
- [Working Holiday now](#)

Q2

Living Situation

- [Lack of established local networks reported as common among new residents](#)
- Participant 1 shares housing with one roommate
- Minimal communication reported with roommate ("Seldom")

Q3

Current Help-Seeking Behaviors and Patterns

Help-Seeking Methods

- [Primary approach: Ask friends for assistance](#)
- [Secondary: Consider handling problems independently](#)
- [Tertiary: May give up on task if help unavailable from known contacts](#)
- [Social media platforms \(Facebook\) used but with limitations](#)
- [Never reported asking neighbors for help](#)

Types of Help Needed

- Pest removal (catching spider in room)
- Furniture moving (moved 2-3 streets with furniture and luggage)
- Small everyday tasks and borrowing items
- Tasks requiring multiple people or specialized help

Q4

Help-Seeking Barriers

- [Introversion and reluctance to ask for help](#)
- [Lack of established neighbor relationships despite proximity](#)
- [Inability to identify who to contact for assistance](#)
- [Discomfort with asking unfamiliar people](#)
- [Geographic and social isolation despite living in populated areas](#)

Q5

(Supplement by Anita) [Seldom communicate with neighbour -> have no experience](#)

Q6

Pain Points with Current Solutions

Social Media Platforms (Facebook/existing groups)

- ["Usually for Facebook it seems like there's a lot of strangers or someone who don't really want to offer help but they are just like having advertisements or some of them are scams"](#)
- [Response delays](#): Typical wait time of several hours for responses; by then alternative solutions often found
- [Authenticity concerns](#): Not all users are genuinely interested in helping
- [Spam and scams](#): Presence of fraudulent activity and commercialization

General Help-Seeking Frustration

- Difficulty finding appropriate help resources
- Slow response times from existing platforms
- Lack of trust in strangers offering help
- Limited ways to connect with neighbours without existing relationships

Q7

(Supplement by Anita) Never use platform (like Nextdoor) to ask for help

Q8

Yes, specially as a new comer for Melbourne, difficult to make friend with local community when first arrived.

Q9

User Feedback and Concerns

Positive Reception

- "I think it's really helpful to me like no matter if I'm a new person in society"
- Perceived as convenient and fast compared to traditional methods
- Credibility system addresses scam concerns
- Reduces hesitation about meeting strangers due to reputation transparency

Q10

- Helpful for international students and newcomers to area
- Borrow something, and life necessities

Q11

Critical Concerns Identified

Cold-Start Problem

- "Initially like if I listening about this app my biggest concern there's not nothing about safety I think it's all right but the only concern is that there are not enough users"
- Initial user base has zero credibility ratings, making trust difficult
- Lack of critical mass of users in early stages limits utility
- Promotion and user acquisition identified as essential for platform viability
- Risk of no responders to help requests in early adoption phase

Q12

Safety and Identity Verification

- Risk assessment concerns when inviting strangers into home
- "if today my life isn't working and I don't really think women could do And if there is a man who responds, and if today I'm living alone, I might be worried that what happens if that man comes inside"
 - => worried about for stranger come inside when only one single girl is at home
- Gender-based safety concerns noted
- Recommend Solution: need the filter in gender

Q13

Yes, Indeed. But better to have connection with the local community. (like Woolworth) To get some promotion or coupon from them

locals.

Solution: (Anita introduced the gamify system for Skylië)

Q14

- Users want ability to verify identity before accepting help, especially in vulnerable situations
- Criminal background verification desired by some users, but concerns about data collection
- "Of course, if they're identified as the best. touch wood if they are having some criminal offense or just about sexual aegis. It's very important for me to trace that cool"
- Real identity preferred over anonymity for safety and accountability purposes
- Users want ability to identify potential risk factors in helpers

Q15

User Preferences

Gender Preferences

- Female users report preference for female helpers in certain contexts
- "especially like, for instance, I'm at home and I'm liking off the menstruation pads. Yeah, and then I don't think men they do have. And I don't want them to know about it"
- Gender-sensitive tasks create privacy concerns
- Gender preference applies to both receiving and offering help in sensitive situations

Age Considerations

- Concerns about teenagers using app without genuine intent to help
- "some teenagers or some who is a kid, they just all due to curiosity, they download the app, but they are playing. They don't really give you no help"
- Risk of pranks or unreliable help from younger users
- Age verification or age-gating may be relevant consideration

Q16

(Add by Anita) Same concern for requirer and supplier

Q17

Design Recommendations from User Feedback

Incentive Mechanisms

- **Credit/Score system:** Beyond reputation, earn credits redeemable for benefits
- **Gamification:** Build virtual homes, neighborhoods, and towns to increase engagement
- "Virtual neighborhoods"
- **Non-monetary benefits:** Preferred over direct monetary rewards by some users
- **Business collaborations:** Partner with local businesses for discounts/coupons on earned credits

Q18

Never use another similar app, so the answer is no.

Q19

Liability and Responsibility

- "there's a like for instance, the old women. She helps me to change the light bulb. But suddenly she falls from the chair and she hurts and she is sent to the hospital. So who will take the responsibility of this?"
- Questions about liability when helpers are injured during task completion

- Responsibility assignment unclear between platform, helper, and help-seeker
- Legal and insurance implications not addressed

Transcript:

Okay, let's start. Hi, thank you for taking the time to speak with us today. We are a group of post-graduate students from the University of Melbourne. We are working on the project called HelpNet, like this. A hyper-local platform that helps community members and international students exchange small text and resources nearby. Before we start we all have received your plan language statement explaining the project like you signed before Do you have any question about it? No, okay. No. Yes. Great. I will also like to ask you a permission to audio recall this conversation So we can review it later. It's okay. Yeah. Yeah, sure. Okay, let's begin Okay, section one. Can you tell me a video about yourself? Like where you live and how long have you been living there? I am living in South Yarra in Melbourne and it's been like 10 months. 10 months already? Yeah, 10 months. So how long have you been in Melbourne? Also 10 months. So you're usually living in South Yarra, which is a southern, right? Okay. That's great. That is why we focus on and How would you describe your relationship with your neighbors or the people around you? I really seldom Communicate and also talk to my neighbors. I even don't really see them. Uh-huh Yeah, so actually I would say like I don't really have any communications with them so Is seldom make you to like have a Like there is no chance for you to make new friends with your neighbor, right? No, there are no chances like we don't We couldn't even meet each other Okay, how would you are you leaving with any others? Yes, I do have one roommate. Yeah Did you often talk to him? Sell them. Sell them. Yeah, okay. That is why we focus on this app. And tell me about something like last time you need help with something small like maybe borrow something or moving a piece of a uniform or running an errand. What did you do? When I need help, right? Yeah. I saw a spider in my room and I wasn't there to catch it so I asked my roommate to help me to do it. Is there any other similar things like this one? Like borrow or something? Or are you facing something tough that you cannot figure it out alone? like moving from one place to another place? Yeah, because I've been living in South Korea for 10 months but I do experience ones for moving and I really need help like having my furniture and also my luggage to move around for like two to three streets further away for my home. Yeah, and at the time I just have me myself and I couldn't really do it myself. So usually you ask your friends for help? Yes, I ask my friends for help. Have you ever had a moment where you needed help but didn't know who to ask or feel uncomfortable for asking? Yeah, sure. Because I am an introvert. So I am not really there? to asking people and to request some help from them. So I usually wanted to deal with it myself. If you face something like this situation, what would you do? Would you just give up? You call your friend directly? Yes, usually I might give up, but like moving my home, I really need help. So I just ask my friends. Never with my neighbors or anyone else. So you don't have any experience, like asking help from your neighbors.

Like, when you try to find help, would you prefer app, social media, or friends if you have to pick one? What kind of help? Like text, like borrow something, or small text, or running an errand? Yeah, usually by text. Or friends. Yeah. Have you ever used a platform like Facebook? Red Note or something like that? I've ever used Facebook. Did you face any pain point about this one? Usually for Facebook it seems like there's a lot of strangers or someone who don't really want to offer help but they are just like having advertisements or some of them are scams. Yeah, not everyone are really genuine for helping. How about like, can that platform give you the immediate response? Immediate response, I think. Not very very usually I need to wait for a few hours which already I do already have another solution to it. Oh, yeah That's that's that's where we platform want to solve. Yeah, and as an international Students or someone who are new to the area. Have you ever feel you like a local support? Yes, I do like like quite a lot of local support kids I'm very new to this area. I don't really have friends in the very, very beginning. And the people around me, I actually do those that I do have the most contact with. So yeah, I do feel like I don't really have support from the community. Okay. Yeah, that is our platform. Why we want this platform? And let me introduce you about our... apps while we, how our apps want to solve the problem. And our, our absence is called helpmate. Helpmate can keep you safe. Yes. Um, at the beginning we fast, like, uh, there is another page here, like, like, uh, in our, in our platform, there is based by the like map. And then in this map, uh, you can have an, uh, need post or support post like you can show your marker on the map and when you enter and when you log in you can see where is the

markers on the map and you can filter by the distance or filter by your needs and when you face something like small task that you cannot solve alone you can post your require onto the platform And anyone who sees your requirement can give you some response and contact you and maybe this will help you immediately. I want to ask a question. Could I filter the gender? We allow users to filter with gender. I know females prefer females' help. Yes, especially like, for instance, I'm at home and I'm liking off the menstruation pads. Yeah, and then I don't think men they do have. And I don't want them to know about it, so I think that if I could filter women is a better way. Yeah, yes. So expand from the map and you can see the like, require support. We also have a friend system edition, like if you continuously work with someone nearby you, and you have a chance to make friends with them. Like if you continuously asking help from that girl, or that girl always asking help from you, and it will finally be maybe good friends. And then it makes you too. connecting to the local network. So, this is basically how our platform works. First, you ask nearby, and the nearby local gives you a source, and then we have a reward system. Like, if you get the help, and you can give some good command from the supporter, and yeah, that is how it works. And now like, and it has the ranking system like this. The one who supports the locals most frequently then can have a higher reward and will have a leaderboard like shows who is the most helper in your local area. We can renew it every week and see who is the most. Kind person in your area and that's also make sure that if you want to ask someone for help You can see this one is like better to solve others question is more trustable Yeah Yeah, so the one who helps and who receive help also have a credibility system. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah this is how apps works and we need some feedback after you listen our app so what's your initial reaction to this idea? What is your initial reaction to this idea? I think it's really helpful to me like no matter if I'm a new person in society or like I'm already living quite a long time it do like it is very helpful as I don't really have like telephone contacts or any ways of contacts with my neighbors and I'm shy to do this and as long as there's an app and I really need some help that I couldn't really do it myself it is a very fast and convenient way and also with When you talk about the credibility, I won't really be very worried if they are scammers or they are someone who did not really help me. So I would like to have this app if this is launched. Would you hesitate to use it? Do you have any concerns about this one? Concerns? any reason would you like may let you stop using this platform? Initially like if I listening about this app my biggest concern there's not nothing about safety I think it's all right but the only concern is that there are not enough users so I think like the promotion is very important as long as there are quite a lot of people in the community using it I could get help and I could also help others Yeah, there are enough users and I think it's okay for me. Yeah. Yeah, because that is what you're talking about. It's our pinpoint. Like how can we find a supporter in the local community? I'm just worried like in a very initial period I asked for help and there's no users. We are not talking about like no one is helping me. It's about the problem of no users that appear that they know about I do have this problem. Yeah, that is a good question. Like I can get a feedback and talk with my teammates. And that does talk about like trust and safety issue. Would you make you trust someone enough to accept help from them or over help to them on this platform? Just I'll talk about the credibility like we could reach ourselves after helping but I am quite sure in the very beginning period all of the people we are having are 0 stars because they are not having like starting to help or starting to ask for help so I think the initial period is the most difficult point is that shall I trust about them for instance if today my life isn't working and I don't really think women could do And if there is a man who responds, and if today I'm living alone, I might be worried that what happens if that man comes inside. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Yes. That is a problem. Okay. How about like, will you do any... like... The identity verification? Yeah, that is the next section we are talking about. Would you prefer remembering someone who anonymous on this platform? Or would you want your real identity visible? What's your reasoning? Of course, if they're identified as the best. touch wood if they are having some criminal offense or just about sexual aegis. It's very important for me to trace that cool. But I'm not sure if the users are willing to do so because they are taking a lot of personal information So I don't want to use this platform. There's also an issue with this Like okay, okay Let's talk about next question if like what's your preference for? Like regarding the helper or request like the gender edge or other factors. I know you are you prefer like Receive the support from the girls and how about age is the age may hurt I think it do not really matter a lot. The only thing I might think it might happen is that some teenagers or some who is a kid, they just all due to curiosity, they download the app, but they are playing. They don't really give you no help. Yeah, they just, okay. I'll do for it, but then at last they're not appearing or they are just maybe taking a toy or like pranks, you know, some teenagers they might do something like that. Yeah. And any other facts as well? I think this might be quite extreme, but they, it might be a problem is that, okay, I'll like back to the question that I need to change my light bulb. And there is a like for instance, the old women. She helps me to change the light bulb. But suddenly she falls from the chair and she hurts and she is sent to

the hospital. So who will take the responsibility of this? Yeah, that is a question. I will talk about who's matching mate. Let me jump to another section. If you could add some features about this platform, what would you add and how would that be? There's a question I want to ask. After they offer help, would they get any reward? No, not just the dating board. You can get a good comment for the supporter or the bad comment. I am thinking if you want to boost the number of users or boost the usage of the app. How about like adding a... Keyfans as well. Credit? Credit and a score. Yeah, a score and credit after you offer help or after you raise safe help. So you could like earn some credit to your account and then like... you could also do some collaborations with different businesses like for instance or today you're having collaborations with wolves yeah you could get a coupon yeah a coupon or might be coupon might be like too much of the like too too much for a starting business you might like doing collaborations like you have a uh uh 10% discount on something yeah yeah How did you boost the usage of it? really monetary leverage. Are you guys a good idea? Just make it easy, not without any money. I think it's better than what I just said. Yeah. And you can also develop more than avatar. You can do your own home, build your own home. Yeah, yeah. After there are a lot of clothes, I do think that the users will know that all is boring, so you could develop more like a home or a town, and then like it's like, um, intangible. It's intangible. What is it called? Like... Chewy. Oh, invisible. Oh, visible. And... Chewy. Chewy. Virtual? Virtual. Oh yeah, virtual. Virtual neighborhoods. Mm-hmm. Yeah, so it's quite cute. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Good. Is there anything you have seen in another app, not necessarily in this app, that you really want to work, like have the same function here? I mean, any other help instead of already having this? Mmm, seems not. I've talked about like... If I really need help, I usually ask friends or like Facebook or retinoids. Oh, yeah. Yeah, that's good. Yes, I don't really think there is anything else about this kind of platform. Oh And like is there anything you want to share with me? I don't think so in this moment. Yeah, yeah. Thank you. Thank you for your like thank you for your time and your answer really valuable. Yes Yeah, thank you. Thank you